it is clear that Abul Fazl himself wasn't immune to the pleasures of a good meal.

Akbar ate only once a day, at no fixed time; he began his meal with milk or curd and ended with a prayer, and he became increasingly fond of vegetarian fare over the years. 'From my earliest years,' said the emperor in one of his Happy Sayings, 'whenever I ordered animal food to be cooked for me, I found it rather tasteless and cared little for it.'[18] However, for all that Akbar was not interested in food and had ascetic taste, the one meal that did come to him every day was anything but frugal.

A 100-odd dishes would arrive in a grand procession of gold, silver and copper dishes, prepared by chefs 'from all countries', cooked with water from the Yamuna and Chenab rivers, mixed with rainwater and a few drops from the Ganga.[19] Abul Fazl classifies the cuisine into three broad types. Sufiana – devoid of meat – might include zard birinj (rice cooked with sugar, ghee, almonds, pistachios, raisins, ginger, saffron and cinnamon), khichri (rice and moong daal, cooked in ghee), halwa or green saag ('one of the most pleasant dishes'). If it wasn't one of Akbar's vegetarian days, the rice might also be cooked with meat, to make qabuli, pulao, halim, or an extravagant dish called bugra, made of meat, flour, ghee, gram, sugar, vinegar, onions, carrots, beets, turnips, spinach, fennel, saffron, ginger, cloves, cardamom, cumin, cinnamon and round pepper. Finally, there was meat cooked on its own, with spices, from kebabs to a whole sheep, or a deboned fowl stuffed with minced meat, eggs, ghee, onions, coriander, ginger, saffron and pepper to make a delicious musamman.

Then, of course, there was an endless variety of pickles and chutneys – of mango, lemon, turnip or carrot, apple, peach or raisins, cucumber, bamboo, brinjal or mustard – along with curd and green salads, ginger, limes and bread, on which last Abul Fazl speaks for the subcontinent when he says that a chapatti 'tastes very well when served hot'.[20]

It was on one such day, writes Nizamuddin, 'when His Majesty was taking his dinner, it occurred to his mind that probably the eyes of some hungry one had fallen upon the food; how, therefore, could he eat it while the hungry were debarred from it?' From that day on, he ordered that he would only eat after a portion of his meal had been distributed to the poor.[21]

Again, in July 1582, some three months after Akbar first celebrated